

NEEL KOTAK

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OBJECTIVE

Technical cybersecurity professional with expertise in consulting on complex and novel solutions for Amazon Web Services (AWS) Professional Services (ProServe) customers and 4+ years of experience in the United States Air Force. Deep technical experience with application security reviews and threat modeling, Continuous Integration/Continuous Deployment (CI/CD SAST) code scanning pipelines, AWS service implementation via Infrastructure-as-Code (IaC), advanced threat hunting, malware analysis, and forensics. Current specializations focus on building scalable security solutions using AWS services and IaC. Seeking technical cybersecurity roles, security engineering positions, and/or software development opportunities where I can leverage my deep technical expertise in threat detection/hunting, security automation, DevSecOps practices, and cloud security understanding. Experience in developing custom security tools, automating incident response workflows, and implementing security controls across enterprise environments.

EDUCATION

Master of Cyber Security, Georgia Institute of Technology 2021 - 2025

Relevant Coursework: Advanced Malware Analysis, Network Security, Information Policy and Management, Secure Computing Systems, Applied Cryptography, Information Security Lab: System and Network Defenses

Bachelor of Computer Science, University of Hawaii at Manoa 2015 - 2019

CERTIFICATIONS

CompTIA Security+ - May 2020

GCFA - Aug 2021; **GCIH** - Jan 2023

Certified Information Systems Security Professional (CISSP) - Jan 2025

DoD 8570: IAT Level III | CSSP Analyst | Incident Responder | TS/SCI with Poly - Dec 2025

AWS Certified Solutions Architect Professional (SAP) - Oct 2025

SKILLS

Cybersecurity	Malicious Activity Hunting with ELK, Forensic Analysis, Penetration Testing
Programming/Scripting	C/C++, Java, JavaScript, HTML/CSS, Python, Terraform, AWS Cloud Development Kit (CDK), Python/Typescript, CloudFormation, Bash, Assembly (x86), cdk_nag, cfn_nag, trivy, semgrep, checkov, bandit, git-secrets
Amazon Web Services	AWS EC2, Amazon Bedrock, AWS Lambda, Amazon S3, Amazon API Gateway, Landing Zone Accelerator (LZA), SecurityHub, GuardDuty, Boto3
Network Protocols	Arkime, Wireshark, Zeek, analysis of common protocols: TCP, UDP, IP, DNS, etc...

EXPERIENCE

AWS Professional Services Consultant Dec 2024 - Present
Amazon Web Services (AWS) *Washington DC, Maryland, and Virginia Metropolitan Area (DMV)*

- Led comprehensive AWS GuardDuty/SecurityHub workshop for 15+ customer security personnel, delivering hands-on training on EventBridge integration, automated remediation workflows, and suppression best practices, resulting in overwhelmingly positive feedback and enhanced customer security automation practices
- Configured and deployed DISA STIG-hardened Palo Alto firewall infrastructure with AWS Gateway Load Balancers (GWLBs) across 5+ DoD workload accounts in air-gapped dev/test/prod environments via AWS LZA cloudformation IaC, enabling mission critical DoD cloud migration by delivering highly-scalable, highly-available (HA), resilient networking solution ready for customer workload onboarding and deployment
- Deployed keycloak identity management solution via AWS ECS Fargate clusters across 5+ DoD workload accounts in air-gapped dev/test/prod environments, enabling PKI-based multi-factor authentication and compliance requirements for mission-critical applications through highly-scalable, resilient containerized architecture

- Implemented and customized AWS SecurityHub Compliance Analyzer (SHCA) for DoD customer's air-gapped Amazon Dedicated Cloud (ADC) environment, modifying CDK typescript/python code to handle air-gapped region-specific DNS configurations and VPC endpoint limitations, enabling automated weekly/monthly NIST 800-53 compliance reporting and documentation uploads across dev/test/prod accounts
- Conducted security reviews for 10+ ProServe projects using threat modeling (STRIDE, DREAD, PASTA) and automated SAST scanning (cdk_nag, cfn_nag, trivy, semgrep, checkov, bandit, git-secrets), identifying and resolving 2-5 critical/high vulnerabilities per project while creating standardized templates and leveraging AWS Automated Security Helper (ASH) scanner along with generative AI to achieve significant efficiency gains in security analysis and artifact generation
- Designed and implemented complex, scalable, and secure AWS solutions tailored to customer needs

AWS Solutions Architect Skillbridge Fellow

Aug 2024 - Nov 2024

Amazon Web Services (AWS)

Remote

- Extensive 12-week program that included real-world reporting to AWS Partner Solutions Architect (PSA) team, intensive bootcamp familiarization with AWS cloud services, and self-study to pass AWS SAA Certification prior to fellowship end
- Applied understanding of Generative AI to create a Amazon Bedrock knowledge base chatbot to query thousands of blogs across hundreds of small-medium sized AWS Partners, assisting Solutions Architects with developing custom-tailored proposals matching customers to AWS partners, increasing overall AWS growth in small-medium business sectors

Cyber Protection Team Mission Element Lead (CPT MEL)

May 2020 - Aug 2024

U.S. Air Force

San Antonio, TX

- Led 10+ member teams on rogue systems investigations for proactive threat hunting on multiple networks spanning over 3000+ endpoints and petabytes of network traffic, uncovering novel APTs Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) which deterred, disrupted, and degraded cyber actors
- Extensive experience with memory and disk based forensic artifacts, including use of volatility, FTK imager, and KAPE forensics for intensive analysis of disk and memory images
- Directed and analyzed countless suspicious and malicious binaries via static and behavioral analysis, enhancing total industry knowledge of sophisticated threat actors
- Wrote extensive python and powershell scripts to automate and search IOCs across large data sets for malicious activity, which amplified efficiency and number of findings across multiple missions
- Wrote multiple technical reports that focused on threat actor findings, assessed network security posture, and recommended mitigation for network referencing NIST 800-53 guidance, bolstering network defenses and reducing adversary attack surface
- Created, reviewed and validated detection rules team playbook for use in ELK stack to enhance detection of IOCs, which reduced indications of false positives

Cyber Security Analyst

Dec 2019 - May 2020

American Savings Bank

Honolulu, HI

- Monitored SIEM, Firewall logs, IDS/IPS for anomalous events and suspicious activity, leading to the detection and mitigation of 20+ potential security threats monthly
- Authored multiple incident response reports for events resulting in confirmed findings across enterprise of 50+ bank branches state-wide
- Conducted weekly vulnerability scan of all bank workstations, servers, and ATMs, contacted server managers to fix patches via nessus/tenable, resulting status tracking via monthly vulnerability reports
- Monitored email alerts for Data Loss Prevention (DLP), PII, and customer information

Engineering Researcher, Advanced Course in Engineering

May 2019 - Aug 2019

Air Force Research Labs (AFRL)

Rome, NY

- Completed rigorous research and graduate-level coursework in a wide breath of cybersecurity topics focused on Red Team Tactics.
- Introduced to Reverse Engineering concepts: Sandbox tested and emulated network services to conduct dynamic behavioral analysis and used debuggers and disassemblers such as GDB, IDA/Ghidra for static analysis.
- Tested of Network Penetration conceptions through use of open source tools Metasploit, Powershell Empire, Unicorn packer, and reverse shells.
- Firewall evasion tactics focused on network baselining, covert Command and Control (C2) channels, packet encapsulation to bypass firewall rules.

Cyber Intern, Advanced Cyber Education

Jul 2018 - Aug 2018

Air Force Institute of Technology (AFIT)

Dayton, OH

- Classroom instruction component on cyberspace operations, cyber war exercises, and cyber officer development focused on the study of cyber and its challenges
- Focused coursework on core cybersecurity concepts, followed by week-long practical capstone Cyber Network Defense Exercise testing Defense in Depth, Systems Analysis, Network Penetration, and Computer Network Defenses
- Received Distinguished Graduate award, top 10 percent performer in program

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